

John 1 1–18 In Depth Bible Study

Five observations about Jesus Christ the eternal Word

Hightower Bible Ministry

Purpose of this study. John opens his Gospel by answering the most important question a person can ask: Who is Jesus Christ? John 1:1–18 teaches that Jesus is the eternal Word, the Creator and source of life, the true Light, the Word who became flesh, and the unique Son who reveals the Father. The goal is not only to identify these truths but also to understand why they call every person to believe in Christ and live as a child of God.

Main Truth

Jesus Christ is the eternal God who became truly human, revealed the Father, and gives new life to everyone who receives Him by faith.

Lesson Objectives

- Observe the repeated words, contrasts, people, actions, and claims in John 1:1–18.
- Explain what the passage teaches about the identity and work of Jesus Christ.
- Use supporting Scriptures to confirm each major teaching without removing verses from their context.
- Apply the passage personally by responding to Christ with faith, worship, witness, and obedience.

Suggested Teaching Plan

Supporting passage	How it supports the point
Opening 5 minutes	Read John 1:1–18 aloud and ask listeners to mark repeated words and titles.
Five points 35–45 minutes	Explain each observation, interpretation, supporting passage, and application.
Discussion 10–15 minutes	Use the questions under each point or select the final review questions.
Response 5 minutes	Invite listeners to state what they now believe about Jesus and how they will respond.

How to Observe John 1 1–18

Before consulting other passages, read John 1:1–18 several times. Observation asks what is actually present in the text. Interpretation asks what those details mean. Application asks how the truth should change belief and conduct.

Repeated and Important Words

Supporting passage	How it supports the point
Word	The personal self-expression of God who was with God, was God, created all things, and became flesh.
Life	The life located in the Word; it includes created life and points toward the eternal life Jesus gives.
Light	God's truth and saving revelation shining into a world darkened by sin.
Witness	Testimony that directs people away from the messenger and toward Jesus.
Receive and believe	Parallel expressions describing a trusting response to Jesus and His name.
Children of God	Those given a new relationship with God through spiritual birth, not natural descent or human achievement.
Flesh	Real human existence. The eternal Word truly entered our condition without ceasing to be God.
Glory grace truth	Qualities revealed in Jesus that echo God's self-revelation in the Old Testament.

Major Contrasts

- Light and darkness verses 4–5 and 9
- John the witness and Jesus the Light verses 6–8 and 15
- The world made through Him and the world that did not know Him verse 10
- His own people rejecting Him and believers receiving Him verses 11–12
- Natural birth and birth from God verse 13
- Moses as servant through whom the law was given and Jesus Christ as the Son through whom grace and truth came verse 17
- The unseen God and the Son who makes Him known verse 18

Structure of the Prologue

- Verses 1–5 The Word in eternity, creation, life, and light
- Verses 6–8 John sent as a witness to the Light
- Verses 9–13 The Light enters the world and people respond
- Verses 14–17 The Word becomes flesh and reveals glory, grace, and truth
- Verse 18 The Son makes the unseen God known

Point 1 The Word Is Eternal and Fully Divine

Primary text John 1:1–2

Big idea: Before creation existed, the Word already existed in personal fellowship with God and shared the divine nature.

Observation

- The phrase “in the beginning” deliberately recalls Genesis 1:1.
- John says the Word “was” in the beginning; the Word does not begin to exist at creation.
- The Word was “with God,” showing personal relationship and distinction.
- The Word “was God,” affirming full deity rather than describing the Word as merely godlike.
- Verse 2 repeats the relationship so the reader holds together both truths: the Word is God and the Word is with God.

Interpretation

John begins before Bethlehem. Jesus’ human life had a beginning in history, but the person of the Son did not begin there. He existed eternally before His incarnation.

The expression “with God” presents the Word as personally distinguishable from the Father, while “was God” identifies His divine nature. John is not teaching that the Father and Son are the same person; he is presenting unity of divine nature together with personal relationship.

“Word” translates the Greek term *logos*. In this passage the Word is not an abstract idea or an impersonal message. The Word creates, gives life, comes into the world, is rejected or received, becomes flesh, and is identified as Jesus Christ in verse 17.

Supporting Scriptures

Supporting passage	How it supports the point
Genesis 1:1	John’s opening reaches back to the beginning of creation and places the Word already there.
John 17:5	Jesus speaks of the glory He shared with the Father before the world existed.
Philippians 2:6–7	Christ existed in the form of God and willingly took the form of a servant.
Colossians 2:9	The fullness of deity dwells bodily in Christ.
Hebrews 1:3	The Son is the radiance of God’s glory and the exact expression of His nature.

Application

- Worship Jesus as Lord, not merely as a teacher, prophet, or created messenger.
- Build your understanding of Jesus on Scripture rather than on personal preference or religious tradition.
- Because Christ is eternal and divine, His words carry God’s authority over every part of life.

Discussion and Teaching Questions

1. What three statements does John make about the Word in verse 1?
2. Why are both “with God” and “was God” necessary for understanding Jesus?

3. How would your obedience change if you consistently remembered that Jesus is God?

Teaching sentence: Jesus did not begin at Bethlehem. He is the eternal Word, personally with the Father and fully divine.

Point 2 The Word Is the Creator Life and Light

Primary text John 1:3–5

Big idea: Everything created came through the Word, and the life found in Him shines as light that darkness cannot defeat.

Observation

- Verse 3 states the truth positively and negatively: all things came through Him, and nothing created came into existence apart from Him.
- The Word belongs on the Creator side of the Creator–creation distinction; He is not included among created things.
- Life is “in Him,” meaning that life is not merely something Jesus possesses secondhand.
- The life becomes the light of humanity, joining creation, revelation, and salvation.
- The light continues to shine. The verb presents ongoing action.
- The term in verse 5 can carry the ideas of grasping, overcoming, or extinguishing. Darkness neither masters the light nor puts it out.

Interpretation

John presents the Word as the divine agent of creation. This excludes the idea that the Word is the first creature, because everything that belongs to the category of created things came into existence through Him.

Light in John includes God’s revelation, moral purity, and saving truth. Darkness represents ignorance, evil, unbelief, and opposition to God. Darkness is real, but it is never equal to the Light.

This theme continues throughout the Gospel. Jesus does not merely point toward light; He declares Himself to be the Light of the world. People reveal their response to God by whether they come to the Light or hide from it.

Supporting Scriptures

Supporting passage	How it supports the point
Genesis 1:3–4	God creates light by His word, preparing the reader for John’s union of Word, life, and light.
Psalms 36:9	God is the fountain of life, and in His light people see light.
Colossians 1:16–17	All things were created through Christ and for Him, and all things hold together in Him.
Hebrews 1:2	God made the world through the Son.
John 8:12	Jesus identifies Himself as the Light of the world and promises the light of life to His followers.

Application

- Bring hidden attitudes and behavior into Christ's light through confession and obedience.
- Do not treat darkness as stronger than Christ. Opposition cannot extinguish His truth.
- Depend on Jesus as the source of spiritual life rather than trying to reform yourself apart from Him.

Discussion and Teaching Questions

4. What does verse 3 exclude from the category of things created apart from the Word?
5. What forms of darkness appear in the world and in the human heart?
6. What would it look like for you to walk in Christ's light this week?

Teaching sentence: The One who made us is also the One who gives us life and shines God's truth into our darkness.

Point 3 The Light Calls for Witness and a Response of Faith

Primary text John 1:6–13

Big idea: God sends witnesses to point people to the true Light, and those who receive Christ by faith are given the right to become God's children.

Observation

- John the Baptist is introduced as a man “sent from God,” but the text immediately states that he was not the Light.
- John's purpose was to bear witness so that people might believe through his testimony.
- The true Light comes into the world He created, yet the world does not recognize Him.
- Jesus comes to His own, but His own people do not receive Him.
- Rejection is not the only response. “But” in verse 12 introduces the promise to those who receive Him.
- Receiving Jesus is explained as believing in His name—trusting who He is and relying on Him.
- Becoming God's child is a gift of authority or right granted by Christ, not the result of ancestry, human desire, or another person's decision.
- The new birth is “of God.”

Interpretation

A faithful witness does not draw attention to himself. John's greatness lies partly in his refusal to take the place that belongs to Jesus. Christian teachers should have the same aim: people should believe in Christ through our testimony, not become dependent on our personality.

The tragedy of verses 10–11 is intensified by the language of creation and ownership. The Creator entered His world, yet the world failed to recognize Him; He came to His own people, yet many refused Him.

Verses 12–13 describe conversion from two sides. Human beings receive and believe; God gives the right to become His children and causes the new birth. Membership in God's family is not inherited through race, family, or religion.

Supporting Scriptures

Supporting passage	How it supports the point
Isaiah 40:3	A voice prepares the way of the Lord, a text applied to John the Baptist later in John 1.
Malachi 3:1	God promises a messenger who will prepare the way before Him.
John 3:3–8	Jesus explains that entrance into God’s kingdom requires birth from the Spirit.
Romans 8:15–16	Believers receive the Spirit of adoption and relate to God as Father.
1 Peter 1:23	Believers are born again through the living and enduring Word of God.

Application

- Ask whether you have only learned facts about Jesus or have personally received and trusted Him.
- Let your witness make Jesus clear rather than making yourself central.
- Do not depend on church background, family heritage, morality, or religious activity for your standing with God.
- Live with the assurance and responsibility of someone who has been welcomed into God’s family.

Discussion and Teaching Questions

7. What was John the Baptist’s purpose, and what was he careful not to claim?
8. How does verse 12 explain what it means to receive Jesus?
9. Which false bases for becoming God’s child are excluded in verse 13?
10. How can your personal testimony point clearly to Christ rather than merely to self-improvement?

Teaching sentence: The gospel demands a response: reject the Light, or receive Christ by faith and be born into God’s family.

Point 4 The Word Became Flesh and Revealed Grace and Truth

Primary text John 1:14–17

Big idea: The eternal Word truly became human and lived among us, revealing divine glory and bringing the fullness of grace and truth.

Observation

- Verse 14 identifies the eternal Word with the One who became flesh.
- “Flesh” emphasizes genuine human existence, not an appearance or disguise.
- The phrase “dwelt among us” literally carries the idea of pitching His tent or tabernacling among us.
- The eyewitness “we” saw His glory, the unique glory of the Son from the Father.
- Jesus is “full” of grace and truth; these qualities are not occasional additions to His character.
- John the Baptist again testifies to Jesus’ priority: although Jesus’ public ministry followed John’s, Jesus existed before him.

- Believers receive from Christ’s fullness—“grace upon grace,” conveying abundant or successive grace.
- Verse 17 contrasts the roles of Moses and Jesus without treating God’s law as evil. The law was given through Moses; grace and truth reached their climactic expression through Jesus Christ.

Interpretation

The incarnation means that the eternal Son assumed a true human nature without surrendering His divine nature. John does not say the Word stopped being God and became only flesh; the Word who was God became flesh.

The tabernacle imagery recalls God dwelling among Israel. God’s presence is now revealed personally in Jesus. His glory appears not only in power and signs but supremely in the humility, suffering, death, and resurrection of the Son.

“Grace and truth” echoes God’s description of Himself as abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness. Jesus does not contradict the God revealed in the Old Testament; He makes God’s character known in its fullest personal revelation.

“Only Son” or “only begotten Son” translates a term emphasizing uniqueness and one-of-a-kind relationship. John’s point is the Son’s incomparable relationship with the Father, not that the Son was created.

Supporting Scriptures

Supporting passage	How it supports the point
Exodus 25:8–9	God directs Israel to build a sanctuary so that He may dwell among them.
Exodus 33:18–23	Moses asks to see God’s glory, forming background for John’s claim that the disciples saw Christ’s glory.
Exodus 34:6	God reveals Himself as abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness, echoed by “grace and truth.”
Luke 1:35	Jesus’ human birth is the work of the Holy Spirit, and He is called the Son of God.
Philippians 2:6–8	The One who existed in God’s form humbled Himself and took true human form.
Hebrews 2:14–17	The Son shared in flesh and blood so He could defeat death and become a merciful High Priest.

Application

- Come to Jesus with confidence because He knows human weakness from true human experience, yet remained without sin.
- Reflect both grace and truth. Grace without truth excuses sin; truth without grace can become harsh and self-righteous.
- Recognize that Christian faith rests in God entering history, not merely in religious ideas or moral principles.
- Receive daily from Christ’s fullness instead of trying to live the Christian life by self-effort.

Discussion and Teaching Questions

11. What does the word “flesh” protect us from misunderstanding about Jesus?

12. How does the tabernacle background enrich “dwelt among us”?
13. Why must Christian teaching hold grace and truth together?
14. Where do you especially need Christ’s grace today?

Teaching sentence: The God who seemed far away came near in Jesus Christ, entering our condition and revealing divine glory full of grace and truth.

Point 5 The Son Makes the Father Known

Primary text John 1:18

Big idea: No human being can discover the invisible God by personal effort; the unique Son, who shares the Father’s intimate fellowship, has fully revealed Him.

Observation

- The verse begins with the limitation of human sight: no one has seen God.
- The Son is described in the closest possible relationship with the Father.
- The Son has “made Him known.” The verb is related to explaining or interpreting; Jesus is the definitive explanation of God.
- Verse 18 completes the movement begun in verse 1: the Word who was with God has entered the world and revealed God.
- The prologue ends by directing the reader into the rest of the Gospel, where Jesus’ words, signs, death, and resurrection reveal the Father.

Interpretation

Scripture sometimes describes people seeing manifestations of God’s presence, but no sinful human being comprehends God in His unveiled fullness. John’s point is that the invisible God must make Himself known.

Jesus is uniquely qualified to reveal the Father because He is the eternal Son in intimate fellowship with Him. Jesus does not offer a secondhand report about God; He reveals the Father from within that eternal relationship.

To know what God is like, look at Jesus as He is presented in Scripture. His compassion, holiness, truth, authority, sacrificial love, and victory reveal the Father’s character. This does not mean the Son is the Father; it means the Son perfectly reveals Him.

Supporting Scriptures

Supporting passage	How it supports the point
Exodus 33:20	God tells Moses that no one can see His unveiled face and live.
John 5:19–23	The Son acts in unity with the Father and deserves the same honor.
John 14:6–9	Jesus is the way to the Father and tells Philip that seeing Him is seeing the Father revealed.
Colossians 1:15	Christ is the image of the invisible God.
Hebrews 1:1–3	God’s climactic speech is in His Son, the exact expression of His nature.
1 Timothy 6:16	God dwells in unapproachable light and cannot be seen in His fullness by human beings.

Application

- Evaluate every claim about God by the revelation of Jesus in Scripture.
- Do not settle for vague belief in a higher power; come to the Father through the Son.
- Study Jesus' words and actions throughout John with the question, "What does this reveal about God?"
- Make Christ central in teaching, testimony, worship, and ministry.

Discussion and Teaching Questions

15. Why must God reveal Himself if human beings are to know Him truly?
16. What does verse 18 teach about the Son's relationship with the Father?
17. Name one quality of Jesus in the Gospels that reveals the Father's character.
18. How can Hightower Bible Ministry keep Jesus at the center of every lesson?

Teaching sentence: Jesus Christ is not merely one source of information about God; He is the unique Son who makes the Father known.

Putting the Five Points Together

Text	Truth	Response
1 John 1:1–2	The Word is eternal and fully divine.	Worship Jesus as Lord.
2 John 1:3–5	The Word is Creator, life, and Light.	Bring your life into His light.
3 John 1:6–13	The Light calls for witness and faith.	Receive Christ and point others to Him.
4 John 1:14–17	The Word became flesh, full of grace and truth.	Depend on His grace and imitate His truthfulness.
5 John 1:18	The Son makes the Father known.	Center your knowledge of God on Jesus.

Final Review Questions

19. What does John 1:1–18 teach about who Jesus was before His birth?
20. How does the passage show that Jesus is not a created being?
21. What do “light” and “darkness” represent in this passage?
22. What is the difference between knowing about Jesus and receiving Him?
23. What does it mean to be born of God?
24. Why is the incarnation necessary for understanding the Christian gospel?
25. How do grace and truth meet perfectly in Jesus?
26. What does Jesus reveal about the Father?
27. Which of the five truths most challenges or encourages you, and why?

Personal Response

One truth I learned about Jesus:

One belief or attitude I need to correct:

One action I will take in response:

One person with whom I can share this truth:

Teacher Closing

John does not permit us to reduce Jesus to a wise teacher or inspiring example. The One who entered the world is the eternal Word through whom the world was made. He is the Life, the Light, and the unique Son who reveals the Father. The proper response is to receive Him, believe in His name, worship Him, and bear faithful witness so that others may believe.